Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Linda Pastan's "Ethics"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion comparing Pastan's speaker's valuation of life-experience while viewing the Rembrandt in the museum compared to her youthful view of the two options offered by her ethics professor include

anecdote,
blank verse,
comparison,
diction,
epiphany,
metaphor,
sigmatism,
theme, and
tone.

The contestant's response should address both the speaker's (the poet's) youthful tone—reinforced through her teacher's "Linda eschews / the burden of responsibility" (lines 1-16, esp. 15-16) and the conscious awareness of the speaker's present-time "old woman, / or nearly so, myself" (lines 17-25, esp. 18-19).

The contestant's comparison might turn on the concept of burden: a relatively young student's failure to understand the burden associated with choice and, on the other hand, the older museum-visitor's realization—perhaps epiphany—that having to choose is not always a matter in the abstract.

The young writer might recognize that the classroom is locus of preparation—in this case ethical preparation—where a burden in the abstract can be safely discussed in preparation for the myriad moments of choosing that identify adulting.

The poem's last line—the speaker's subtle lament—might be recognized as an eloquent reminder that the school of hard knocks does provide an education . . . that life is, indeed, ***the*** classroom.